

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

DOW JONES | News Corp *****

WEDNESDAY, FEBRUARY 26, 2025 ~ VOL. CCLXXXV NO. 46

WSJ.com

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What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **The S&P 500 and Nasdaq** fell 0.5% and 1.4%, respectively, extending a losing streak into a fourth consecutive session as economic worries and tariff fears dragged on markets. The Dow ticked up 0.4%. **B1**

◆ **Confidence among U.S. consumers** registered the largest monthly decline in more than three years in February. **A2**

◆ **Nvidia's popularity** remains high among individual investors, many of whom are positioning for the graphics-chip maker's shares to rally after Wednesday's earnings report. **B1**

◆ **Unilever unexpectedly** replaced its chief executive, effective March 1, as the consumer-products maker seeks to accelerate a program to revive its fortunes. **B1**

◆ **Dockworkers voted** in favor of a new labor deal that delivers a 62% pay raise and the promise of labor peace at ports from Maine to Texas for the next six years. **B3**

◆ **Approximately 100,000 U.S. aluminum-industry jobs** could be in jeopardy due to tariffs targeting the metal, according to Alcoa Chief Executive William Oplinger. **B2**

◆ **Private-equity firm Roark** is in advanced talks to acquire Dave's Hot Chicken for roughly \$1 billion, people familiar with the matter said. **B3**

◆ **Krispy Kreme said it** expects higher sales this year, though the doughnut chain's shares fell after the outlook missed Wall Street estimates. **B3**

◆ **BlackRock cut** references to its diversity, equity and inclusion strategy in its latest annual report, joining the list of Wall Street firms distancing themselves from DEI. **B12**

World-Wide

◆ **Ukraine agreed to a** mineral-rights deal with the U.S. that could be completed as soon as Friday at a White House meeting between Trump and President Volodymyr Zelensky of Ukraine. **A1**

◆ **Republicans squeaked** their budget blueprint through the House after party leaders swayed a handful of wavering members to back the framework for Trump's tax, border and spending-cut agenda. **A1**

◆ **The Trump administration** created a registry for immigrants in the U.S. illegally to submit their personal information or face fines and prison time, according to documents including a draft regulation seen by The Wall Street Journal. **A3**

◆ **A federal judge in Seattle** ordered the Trump administration to restart the refugee admissions program that legally resettles people from across the globe, which the president had ordered shut down. **A3**

◆ **Sen. Chuck Grassley**, chairman of the Senate Judiciary Committee, sent UnitedHealth Group's CEO a letter demanding detailed information about the company's Medicare billing practices. **A3**

◆ **The White House will** pick which news organizations and reporters can be part of the press pool that rotates access to the president, wresting control from the nonpartisan group that now oversees assignments. **A4**

◆ **Hamas agreed to** proceed with handing over four more dead hostages in exchange for Israel releasing hundreds of Palestinian prisoners, Egyptian officials said, potentially salvaging the cease-fire in Gaza. **A7**

CONTENTS Opinion..... A13-15
Arts in Review..... A11 Personal Journal A9-10
Business & Finance B2-11 Property Report... B6
Business News..... B3 Sports..... A12
Crossword..... A12 Technology..... B4-5
Heard on Street... A13 U.S. News..... A2-5
Markets..... B12 World News..... A6-8



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Disaster Strikes South Korea Highway Project



CATASTROPHE: An elevated section of a highway being built in South Korea collapsed on Tuesday, killing four workers. **A8**

Russia's Withering Economy Is a Tricky Place to Do Deals

By GEORGI KANTCHEV
AND JOE WALLACE

President Trump has said he wants to see major economic deals with Moscow and is in advanced talks to put some together. But how viable a partner is Vladimir Putin's Russia, its economy weakened by years of Western sanctions, its population falling and the prospect of aggressive state intervention rarely far away? Optimists in the White

House point toward a new era of cooperation if a deal can be made to end the war in Ukraine. Even if Europe isn't fully on board, it might still offer opportunities, especially in the extraction of minerals critical to the tech industry or oil and gas, the thinking goes.

But today's Russia doesn't offer a strong investment case. Despite its resilience during the Ukraine war so far, its resource-dependent economy is slowing under the weight of

runaway inflation, sky-high interest rates and Western sanctions. Even if the U.S. were to lift some sanctions, Europe is unlikely to follow suit, leaving Russia a compliance nightmare.

An unpredictable business environment in Russia, where asset seizures by the state have become the norm, would also deter foreign investors. The Russian economy, meanwhile, has become dependent on China, and any returning

Western company would face stiff competition from entrenched Chinese players.

"There will be no economic normalization between the U.S. and Russia for years to come," said Maria Shagina, senior fellow focusing on economic sanctions at the International Institute for Strategic Studies, a think tank.

Trump spurred talk about deals when on Monday, the third anniversary of Russia's

Please turn to page A6

Ukraine Reaches Minerals Pact With Trump

Zelensky to sign agreement at White House as soon as Friday, president says

KYIV—Ukraine has agreed to a mineral-rights deal with the U.S. that could be completed as soon as Friday at a White House meeting between President Trump and President Volodymyr Zelensky of Ukraine.

By Jane Lytvynenko,
Alexander Ward
and Ian Lovett

People close to the negotiations said the text had been agreed upon, and the U.S. had dropped its previous demand for the right to \$500 billion in potential revenue from the development of Ukraine's mineral resources.

"It's a very big deal. It could be a trillion-dollar deal," Trump said on Tuesday. "We're spending hundreds of billions of dollars on Ukraine and Russia fighting a war that should have never ever happened."

The signing ceremony would be a personal victory for Zelensky, who has been pushing for a face-to-face meeting with Trump but has instead had to watch as the U.S. opened discussions with

Please turn to page A6

◆ **Trump moves push Europe to boost security.....** **A6**

AI Data Center Boom Falls Far Short On Jobs

By TOM DOTAN

In Abilene, Texas, some 1,500 people are building the first data center for the StarGate artificial-intelligence venture led by OpenAI.

Once it is completed, a lot fewer people will work there. The facility will have about 100 full-time employees, according to the city's economic development agency. That total is a fraction of the number of people who might work on the same one million square feet if it were an office park, factory or warehouse. A 286,500-square-foot cheese-packaging plant that broke ground in Abilene in 2021 was projected to employ 500 people.

"Data centers have rightly earned a dismal reputation of creating the lowest number of jobs per square foot in their facilities," said John Johnson, chief executive of data-center operator Patmos Hosting.

Silicon Valley's race to build advanced AI systems has sparked a related frenzy to build data centers with the chips needed to power them. Tech giants including Amazon.com, Google and Microsoft operate 445 data centers in the U.S. and have 249 in the pipeline, according to Synergy Research Group. StarGate plans to build at least 20. Their spending totals hundreds of billions of dollars annually.

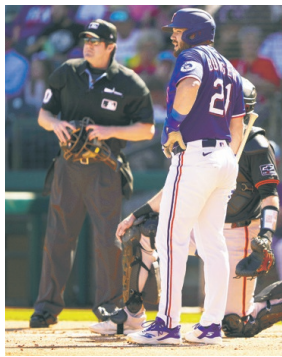
Politicians and business leaders have touted data centers as a boon for employment. At the news conference unveiling StarGate, President Trump said more than 100,000 new jobs would be created "almost immediately." OpenAI published a blog post that said StarGate would "create hundreds of thousands of American jobs."

Please turn to page A2

INSIDE



PERSONAL JOURNAL
Home buyers finally get the upper hand amid growth in supply of housing. **A10**



SPORTS
Robot umpires have arrived, but the system has led to challenges from pitchers. **A12**

Church Pensions Sidestep Oversight

Fund collapses at religiously affiliated hospitals upend retirees' plans

By THEO FRANCIS

Anne Hotaling joined St. Clare's hospital in Schenectady, N.Y., fresh out of nursing school in 1979. She came to see the Roman Catholic hospital and her fellow workers as a second family, an extension of the tightknit

Catholic community in which she had grown up.

The job came with long-term financial security: a pension plan that eventually promised Hotaling, following her retirement, \$1,449 a month for life. It was one reason she turned down

Please turn to page A8

The Missing \$25 Gift Card That's Rocking the Hamptons

Mystery has prompted a disciplinary trial and derailed a school principal's career

By JOSHUA CHAFFIN |

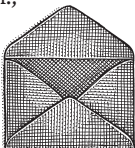
On this, the townfolk of Amagansett agree: On Friday, Dec. 15, 2023, at 8:37 a.m., principal Maria Dorr emerged from the mailroom at the local elementary school with a red envelope in hand.

Whether it was rightfully hers is a

question that has convulsed the small town on the eastern edge of New York's Long Island ever since.

By some measures, the stakes could not be lower. A red envelope that went missing—or was stolen—from the school's mailroom on that day was said to

Please turn to page A10



Priority mail

House Passes Plan Of Tax, Budget Cuts

WASHINGTON—Republicans squeaked their budget blueprint through the House late Tuesday after party leaders swayed a handful of wavering members to back the framework for President Trump's tax, border and spending-cut agenda.

By Richard Rubin,
Olivia Beavers
and Siobhan Hughes

The 217-215 vote delivered a victory for House Speaker Mike Johnson (R., La.), who united all but one of his GOP members—Thomas Massie of Kentucky—around an approach that requires significantly reducing Medicaid costs and likely won't accommodate all of Trump's desired tax cuts. The House-passed plan calls for \$1.5 trillion to \$2

trillion in spending reductions over a decade and \$4 trillion to \$4.5 trillion in tax cuts.

Tuesday's vote is a sign that the Republican-controlled Congress might be able to deliver major legislation despite slim majorities in the House and Senate.

Still, the path ahead isn't straightforward. Tuesday's vote sets up a conflict with the Senate, which favors larger tax cuts and plans to alter the House plan rather than accept it. That means another nail-biting House budget vote is on the horizon.

And even after the House and Senate agree on a budget, lawmakers will have to negotiate hundreds of details on taxes, health care, energy and food stamps before they can get a bill to Trump's desk.

Please turn to page A5

Agentforce
can help
thousands of
shoppers with
spot-on style recos.
Every second.

Agentforce What AI Was Meant to Be